The Next Big Thing



It's a 600 million-year-old geographical feature that encircles a 1,000-year-old temple, and Rajasthan Tourism feels it's high time to develop it as a tourist attraction. If fame has eluded the Ramgarh Crater, it's because the site remained shrouded in geological mystery. Was it the result of volcanic activity or an asteroid strike? The place has always been remarkable enough to attract notable figures—it was mapped by Kishen Singh Rawat a.k.a. 'AK', one of the famous 'Pundits' who surveyed Tibet in disguise, and the geologist John Bicknell Auden (brother of the poet W.H. Auden) was among those who speculated that the crater was the result of an intrusion of magma. Fortunately for Baran district, in the southwestern corner of the state, scientific consensus has shifted overwhelmingly to the position that Auden was wrong and this is, in fact, the rarer kind of crater: of extra-terrestrial origin. Which makes Ramgarh India's second largest 'astrobleme' (after the Lonar crater). The government reportedly plans to spend several crores on developing the place as a tourist hotspot. You might want to get there first.

WHAT'S NEW IN TOURISM IN...



GOA

Rohan Khaunte, Minister of Tourism: "Monsoon tourism has picked up in Goa. Goa is also looking to promote local festivals to attract tourists. These include Shigmo, Heritage, Spirit of Goa, Deepotsav, Food & Cultural, Carnaval, Vintage, Chikal Kalo, Sao Joao, and Bonderam. From the vibrant colours and traditional music of Shigmo to the lively parades and costumes of Carnaval, these festivals provide an opportunity for tourists to immerse themselves in the local traditions and celebrations. The new airport is having a significant impact. With improved connectivity, more tourists are able to conveniently reach Goa."



TAMIL NADU

Dr K. Manivasan, Principal Secretary, Tourism: "Tamil Nadu is tapping into the state's tourism potential with a comprehensive master plan for 300 destinations. It also launched the Tamil Nadu Tourism Destination Development Scheme in 2021 for the holistic development of tourist spots. Lesser-known destinations like Kolli Hills, Jawadhu Hills and Yelagiri are currently being developed. The state is also actively working on creating greenfield destinations such as Vathalmalai, Muthukuda and Muthupettai. To promote eco-tourism, niche products like eco-camping and adventure activities at hill stations, beaches and dam sites are being developed. The International Surf Open Championship will be held for the first time in India at Mamallapuram in 2023."



RAJASTHAN

Gayatri Rathore, Principal Secretary, Tourism: "Rajasthan being the most favoured tourist destination has witnessed a tremendous increase in the footfall of travellers in the past two years. Our innovative marketing campaigns are driving factors for increasing this footfall further. Rajasthan Tourism is trying to showcase its beautiful, natural, rural landscapes through the Rural Tourism Policy. We are also working on making Rajasthan the best place for destination weddings. The revival of the luxury train 'Palace on Wheels' has been a major attraction for luxury travellers."



GUJARAT

Hareet Shukla, Secretary, Tourism: "Gujarat Tourism is focusing on promoting new destinations like Dholavira, Shivrajpur, Sasan Gir and Dharoi. The tourism department is also targeting adventure tourism, food festivals, cultural events, and handicraft fairs. Dharoi as a destination is envisioned to be a central regional core, facilitating the North Gujarat circuit. Dholavira is to be developed as an 'Iconic Tourist Destination'. And so is Sasan Gir, the only habitat of the Asiatic Lion. The Dwarka Corridor project comprises the world's largest statue of Lord Krishna, 3D immersive centre, Shrimad Bhagwat Gita Experience Zone and a viewing gallery of the extinct city."



UTTARAKHAND

Sachin Kurve, Secretary, Tourism, and CEO, Uttarakhand Tourism Development Board: "George Everest Estate in Mussoorie has been developed with the restoration of George Everest's House, heritage museum, eco huts, restaurant and the nearby heliport facility. We recently announced whitewater rafting on the Bhagirathi in Harsil Valley, near Uttarkashi. The state is also promoting breakfast tourism, heli tourism, rural tourism, astro tourism and varied experiences in adventure tourism. Cave tourism is also being explored. A pilgrim circuit in Kumaon (Manaskhand) on the lines of the Char Dham in Garhwal (Kedarkhand) is in the works."